

MaHIS Data Privacy and Usage Policy

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1.0 - What information we collect

The Digital Health Division of the Ministry of Health Malawi operates the Malawi Healthcare Information System (MaHIS). MaHIS is used by authorised healthcare workers in supported clinical programmes. This policy covers information processed through the mobile, web and desktop versions of MaHIS, including information stored or used while the app is offline.

1.1 - Patient identity, demographic and contact information

Depending on the service being provided, MaHIS records information such as a patient's name, health or programme identifiers, date of birth or age, sex, phone number, address, facility, next-of-kin or relationship information and other details needed to identify the correct patient and coordinate care.

1.2 - Health and clinical information

MaHIS is an electronic health information system used by authorised healthcare workers. Depending on the clinical programme, it records information including patient demographics and identifiers, symptoms, diagnoses, observations and vital signs, medications, allergies, laboratory orders and results, immunisation history, pregnancy and maternity information, appointments, referrals, clinical notes, outcomes and related care records. The system also records the responsible facility and healthcare worker where required for patient care, accountability and audit purposes.

1.3 - Healthcare-worker accounts and audit information

For authorised users, MaHIS processes account and work information such as name, username, assigned roles, programmes, facility, authentication tokens, login times and the identity of the user responsible for creating or changing a record. Where passkey login is enabled, MaHIS stores a passkey credential identifier and public key, an Android or web platform label, a device label supplied by the browser, supported passkey transport information and the last time the passkey was used. MaHIS does not receive or store fingerprint, face or other biometric templates.

1.4 - Technical, connection and printer information

MaHIS processes a limited amount of technical information needed to connect, authenticate, print and deliver compatible software updates:

- MaHIS servers, facility servers, CouchDB services, network proxies and approved update services may receive a source IP address and standard HTTP information such as browser or WebView type as part of an ordinary network connection. Operational server or proxy logs may record this information.
- The app reads its installed version, operating platform and processor architecture to select a compatible update. When the Android updater downloads an update, the update host receives a MaHIS updater identifier and the installed MaHIS version in the request.
- When an authorised user configures a network printer, MaHIS stores the printer name, type, IP address, port and facility. The configuration may be stored in local CouchDB or sent to MaHIS Core.
- When a user opens printer discovery, MaHIS accesses paired Bluetooth printers and available USB printers. Printer names and hardware addresses may be shown to the user, and the selected default printer may be stored on that device.

MaHIS does not currently use Firebase Cloud Messaging identifiers, advertising identifiers or analytics trackers. It does not collect flight numbers, vehicle registration numbers, ship numbers, mobile-network operator or Internet-service-provider names, connection speed, or information from wearables and smart TVs. MaHIS does not combine activity across unrelated devices for advertising, profiling or fraud analytics, and it does not scan the local network for unrelated devices.

1.5 - Information stored for offline use

Authorised deployments can store clinical records, reference data, printer settings and pending work locally in the app's database or in a facility CouchDB service so healthcare can continue during connectivity interruptions. The app can also keep an encrypted offline-login snapshot containing the user's session, roles, programmes and facility information. That snapshot permits offline sign-in for up to 30 days after a successful online login. The user's password is not stored; it is used to derive the encryption key. Locally created or changed records are synchronised with authorised MaHIS systems when connectivity is available.

2.0 - How information is used

MaHIS uses information only for authorised health-service and system-operational purposes, including:

- identifying the correct patient and maintaining a longitudinal clinical record;
- supporting clinical assessment, treatment, medication, laboratory, immunisation, maternity, referral, appointment and follow-up workflows;
- coordinating care between authorised facilities, programmes and healthcare workers;
- producing authorised clinical, operational and public-health reports;
- supporting offline work and synchronising records when connectivity returns;
- authenticating users, applying role-based access, supervising eligible workflows and maintaining audit trails;
- printing labels and documents, scanning supported barcodes or QR codes and exporting user-requested reports;
- selecting compatible app updates, diagnosing operational failures, protecting the service and improving data quality.

MaHIS is a clinical record and workflow tool for authorised healthcare workers. It does not replace professional clinical judgement. Patients should consult a qualified healthcare professional for medical advice, diagnosis or treatment.

MaHIS does not sell personal or health information, use it for advertising, or use third-party analytics to track which screens users view. The app does not send cloud push notifications through Firebase Cloud Messaging.

3.0 - When information is shared

3.1 - Authorised healthcare and Ministry use

Information may be made available to authorised healthcare workers, facilities, Ministry of Health programmes and public-health authorities when required to provide care, operate MaHIS, maintain shared records, conduct authorised supervision or meet reporting obligations. Access is limited by the user's assigned role and operational need.

3.2 - Service and platform providers

Approved service providers may process information on behalf of the Ministry when they host, maintain, support or secure MaHIS infrastructure. Google Play and approved software-update hosting services may receive limited technical connection information when they distribute the app or an update. Their independent processing is governed by their own terms and privacy notices.

3.3 - Legal and safety requirements

Information may be disclosed when required by applicable law, a valid court or government order, an authorised public-health mandate, or when necessary to protect patients, users, the public or MaHIS systems. Only information reasonably necessary for the authorised purpose should be disclosed.

4.0 - App permissions and device features

MaHIS requests device access only when it is needed for a supported feature. A user can deny optional access, but the related feature may then be unavailable.

4.1 - Camera

MaHIS uses the camera when a user starts barcode or QR-code scanning for supported patient-identification and clinical workflows. MaHIS does not use the camera in the background.

4.2 - Bluetooth and nearby devices

MaHIS uses Bluetooth permissions only when an authorised user configures or prints to a nearby label printer. On Android 11 and earlier, Android may require a location permission to discover Bluetooth devices. MaHIS does not use this permission to collect or store the device's geographic location.

4.3 - Files and storage

When a user chooses to export a report, label or other document, MaHIS uses Android storage facilities to save the selected file. Legacy storage permissions are requested only on older Android versions where they are required.

4.4 - Device authentication

Where passkey login is enabled, MaHIS asks the operating system or browser to verify the healthcare worker using the device's configured biometric, PIN or screen lock. The operating system performs that verification; MaHIS does not receive or store the biometric template.

4.5 - Managed application updates

The Google Play distribution is updated by Google Play. Ministry-managed or VPN distributions may ask the user to install a Ministry-signed MaHIS update. This managed update function verifies the package identity, version, checksum and signing certificate before Android presents its installation confirmation.

5.0 - Storage, offline operation, synchronisation and retention

Depending on the authorised deployment, information may be stored on a Ministry-managed central server, a facility server, a facility CouchDB service or the authorised user's device. Offline copies are used to keep approved clinical workflows available without a reliable network connection and are synchronised with authorised systems when connectivity returns.

Personal and health records are retained according to applicable law, Ministry health-record and public-health policies, clinical-safety requirements, audit requirements and the configuration of the authorised deployment. Local caches, encrypted offline-login records, exports and backups follow their applicable operational or retention procedures. An exported file is controlled by the user and device environment after the user saves or shares it.

6.0 - How information is protected

MaHIS uses role-based access, authenticated sessions, optional passkeys, audit trails, controlled facility and programme assignments, encrypted offline-login snapshots and other administrative and technical safeguards. Access is limited to authorised personnel according to their responsibilities.

Public internet deployments use encrypted connections. Some Ministry-managed local or VPN deployments may connect to approved facility servers, CouchDB services or printers over a protected local network where transport encryption is not available. Those networks must be restricted and protected by the responsible Ministry or facility administrators.

No system can be completely secure. Suspected loss, misuse or unauthorised access should be reported promptly to software-developers@kuunika.org.

7.0 - Information about children

MaHIS is not a consumer app directed to children, and its patient records are not accounts for children to operate the app. However, MaHIS is a healthcare system and therefore records health information about children, newborns and adolescents when authorised healthcare workers provide care or carry out approved public-health programmes. That information is handled as part of the official health record under applicable healthcare, consent, safeguarding and Ministry procedures.

8.0 - Access, correction and deletion requests

A patient or authorised representative may contact the responsible facility or the Data Protection Officer to request access to or correction of personal information, subject to identity verification and applicable Ministry procedures. Authorised healthcare workers may correct records only through approved clinical and audit processes.

A person may also request export or deletion where applicable. Some clinical, public-health, legal and audit records cannot be deleted or may need to be retained to protect patient safety and the integrity of the official health record. Where a request cannot be completed, the responsible authority should explain the applicable restriction.

9.0 - Applicable law and approved deployments

MaHIS is primarily operated for authorised health services in Malawi. Information must be processed under applicable Malawi law, Ministry of Health mandates, health-record requirements and the governance rules of the authorised deployment. If another privacy regime applies to a specific deployment or person, any additional notice and rights required by that regime will apply.

Organisations or service providers processing MaHIS information on behalf of the Ministry must act only within their approved role, protect the information and follow applicable Ministry security, confidentiality and data-governance requirements.

10.0 - Contacting the Digital Health Division

Privacy questions, requests or suspected security incidents may be directed to the Data Protection Officer:

Dr. Alinafe Mbewe,
Digital Health Division, Deputy Director
Ministry of Health,
Republic of Malawi
nafekmbewe@gmail.com